

STRESS CORNER . HERB FORMULARY



The Stress Corner Herb Formulary

The herbs I trust for this corner, each with its dose, why it helps, and the cautions that matter.

by Joel Polley, RN

BRAVEWORKS RN . REGISTERED NURSE, NATUROPATHIC PRACTITIONER

THE BP TRIANGLE . STRESS . SUGAR . SODIUM

The Stress Corner Herb Formulary

These are the adrenal and calming herbs for the stress corner, where the goal is to bring an overworked cortisol system back down. They are educational and meant to work alongside your doctor, never instead. The universal rule lives at the top of every formulary in this kit: add ONE at a time, check your blood pressure daily, and tell your doctor everything you are taking.

THE ONE RULE THAT GOVERNS EVERY HERB HERE

Add ONE at a time. Check your blood pressure daily. Tell your doctor everything you are taking. If you are on BP medication these can lower your pressure further, which is the goal under monitoring; if readings run consistently below about 110/70 or you feel dizzy, call your doctor about your medication dose. Never stop or change a prescription on your own.

The Formulary

Herb / nutrient	Dose / use	Why it helps	Caution
Ashwagandha (Withania somnifera) The keystone cortisol reducer	300 to 600 mg daily of a KSM-66 or Sensoril standardized extract, with food, morning or early afternoon. Start at 300 mg for the first week, increase to 600 mg if tolerated.	An adaptogen that calms the HPA axis, the master stress-response system, and reduces cortisol output. In a gold-standard randomized trial it lowered serum cortisol by 28 to 30 percent. The full effect builds over 2 to 4 weeks; calmer mood and better sleep often appear within days.	Avoid if pregnant or nursing. May raise thyroid hormone, so use caution and check with your doctor if you have a thyroid condition. Tell your doctor if you take any sedative or thyroid medication.

Herb / nutrient	Dose / use	Why it helps	Caution
Magnesium glycinate The relaxation mineral, the throughline of the whole triangle	300 to 400 mg daily, with dinner or before bed. Glycinate is the gold-standard form for absorption and calm. Taurate is also excellent for cardiovascular support. Avoid magnesium oxide (only about 4 percent absorbed). An evening Epsom-salt bath (a cup or two, soak about 20 minutes) adds magnesium through the skin.	Barbara O'Neill calls magnesium the relaxation mineral, and it earns the name. Chronic stress drains it fast, and replacing it calms the nervous system through the GABA pathway, supports sleep, and relaxes blood vessels. The one supplement that works in more than one corner: here it calms the nerves, in the sodium corner it relaxes vessel walls.	If you take a calcium-channel blocker such as amlodipine, the mechanisms add up, so monitor daily. Citrate forms can loosen stools. Magnesium is cleared by the kidneys, so if you have reduced kidney function, talk with your doctor first and let your readings guide the dose.
Tart cherry The sleep restorer	Taken in the evening. The source lists tart cherry as the sleep-support pairing with magnesium glycinate and does not specify a milligram dose for this corner. Follow product labeling and your doctor's guidance for the exact amount.	A natural source of melatonin that supports sleep onset and quality. Better sleep means a deeper overnight blood-pressure dip and more vascular repair, exactly the window chronic cortisol steals.	Generally gentle. As with all of these, introduce it on its own and tell your doctor.
Passionflower The sympathetic calmer	The source describes passionflower's use for anxiety-related blood pressure but does not specify a milligram dose. Follow product labeling and your doctor's guidance, and add it only after your foundation herbs are steady.	Works on GABA receptors to calm the fight-or-flight nervous system and ease the adrenaline surge that drives pressure up. Calming without heavy sedation, listed as the natural counterpart to the beta-blocker pathway.	Can add to the effect of sedatives and blood-pressure medication. Introduce alone, monitor daily, and tell your doctor, especially if you take any calming or sleep medication.

Herb / nutrient	Dose / use	Why it helps	Caution
Lemon balm (Melissa officinalis) The gentle settler	The source names lemon balm as a calming natural counterpart but does not specify a milligram dose for this corner. Follow product labeling and your doctor's guidance.	A gentle calming herb that pairs well with passionflower for a keyed-up, cannot-settle feeling.	Generally gentle; may add to sedative effects. As always, one at a time, monitor, and tell your doctor.

Daily supports (free, and the backbone)

Free, and the backbone of this corner: box breathing (4-4-4-4) mid-afternoon and long-exhale breathing (in 4, hold 4, out 6) at bedtime to activate the vagus nerve; a 20-minute unhurried walk in morning sunlight; an evening gratitude practice; prayer and Scripture to strengthen the cortisol brake ("Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you," 1 Peter 5:7); no caffeine (swap to chamomile or hibiscus tea), screens off by 9 PM, a cool dark room.

© BraveWorks RN . Joel Polley, RN . bpquiz.com. For educational purposes only. Not medical advice, not a diagnosis, not a prescription. Always consult your healthcare provider before combining any herb or supplement with prescription medication, and never change a medication on your own.